handed its winning card. In the potential instability that followed the death of any monarch, the Mughals might well swoop in upon Samarqand as they had upon Gujarat and Bengal.

Akbar wanted to send Salim off immediately. The eldest prince was made of more stubborn stuff than his brothers, however, and he would not go haring off on his father's command as they had. Or, as Abul Fazl puts it, the 'pleasure-loving youth . . . could not wean his heart from India'.

Some of Akbar's amirs proposed to go in Salim's place, but Akbar was reluctant to let them: 'Now that Turan is a seat of turmoil, how does an expedition there agree with our humanity?' he declared with rhetorical flourish, having seemingly forgotten all about the divinely ordained civilizing missions that had won him other neighbouring kingdoms.

Maybe Akbar wanted someone from the family to go and claim the family seat. If Salim refused, the emperor 'would send whichever one of [his other sons] showed an inclination for the task', he said. But how was he to send them if they wouldn't show him their faces?

Abul Fazl describes how Akbar had taken to reserving one day a week for various kinds of inspections: horses on Sundays, camels, cows and mules on Mondays, and soldiers on Tuesdays. Wednesdays and Thursdays were reserved for financial and judicial matters, Fridays he spent with the harem, and Saturdays mustering his beloved elephants.[78] The whole empire, it seems, was paraded before Akbar; only his sons would not appear. Murad made excuses for not coming to court. Daniyal, less brazen than his elder siblings, agreed to return, without actually returning.

By November that year, a wasted eleven months after Abdullah died, Akbar had realized that if he wanted the great city of Samarqand, the city that Babur had so hoped to rule, he would have to go and get it himself. Once again, Akbar made a plan. He would leave Punjab, find Murad in the south and give him a piece of his mind, and, having conquered the Deccan, return to take Turan.

Once again, however, as was so often the case now with so many of Akbar's plans, it was not to be. The emperor had travelled from Lahore to Agra by the end of the year, all set to give Murad more lectures on kingship, but then, uncharacteristically, he stopped. Something about Murad's and Daniyal's refusal to come to court was troubling him; Akbar was 'uneasy',